



Pink Himalayan Salt

There are many supposed health benefits of Pink Himalayan Salt, but little evidence to support the claims. <https://digit.in/apr20-57>



Asín tibuok

Take a peak into the process used by the last saltmakers of Bohol, a very long procedure, going extinct. <https://digit.in/apr20-57>



pans, using methods that have been more or less the same since the time of the Incans. The Peruvian pink salt is a finishing salt, similar to the Himalayan pink salt.

The Alaea salt, also known as Red Hawaiian salt has a dark red colouration, caused by the volcanic clay in the region that it is extracted from. There are trace amounts of over 80 different minerals, many of which are rich in iron oxide.

The Persian Blue Salt is extracted from the Ergourz mountain range in Northern Iran. Unlike most of the other coloured salts in this section, it is not the minerals that cause the distinctive blue coloration. The colouration is actually caused by the extreme compression that the salt deposits from evaporated water bodies had to undergo. The process converted the salt to something between a fossil and a gemstone. This salt originates from ancient deposits, more than 100 million years old. It is this that causes

the blue colouration, which is similar to the colour of compressed ice in glaciers. The flavour is intense and described as “lemony” and even “sweet”. The salt is also rich in iron, calcium and potassium.

Fleur de sel is one of the oldest varieties of salt, documented to be used by humans. Pliny the Elder mentions the salt as Flos Salis in his Natural History, published around 77 CE. Fleur de sel is one of the rarest and most expensive finishing salts in the world, and the cost has to do with the method of extraction. In the salt pans, the salt deposited on the bottom of the pans are harvested regularly, as sea salt. However, some of the salt floats to the top of the receding and evaporating waters, forming a thin crust of fragile flower like structures. It is this fragile salt that is raked up by hand, and is considered a delicacy. Most of the Fleur de sel is harvested off the coast of Brittany in France, particularly in the town Guérande. However, the salt is also harvested in Portugal, Spain and Greece. The salt is not further processed, and consumed raw. Another sea salt with a strong flavour is called Sel de Mer, and is extracted in Italy and France. The salt is rich in magnesium, and is also known as the Mediterranean sea salt. It has a strong flavour, and thus, lesser quantities of salt is necessary. Similar to Fleur de sel, Sel de Mer is also consumed entirely unprocessed. Sel de Mer is grey in colour.

Namibian Salt Pearls are produced naturally from a very unique combination of circumstances. The chunks of salt roll out of the sea in protected regions of South Africa. The interaction with winds from the mountain plateaus, known as Berg Winds, cause the salt to roll from the pans naturally. The rolling action “polishes” them, or gives them a pearl like appearance. The Namibian Salt Pearls have trace amounts of magnesium and calcium. Some of the Namibian Salt Pearls actually come from Lake Assal in Djibouti, which is a body of water saltier than the Dead Sea.

SPECIAL PROCESSES

The colouration and flavour of some salts is not only because of their place of origin, but rather a special type of processing on the salt after extraction. The most famous example of this is black salt, known locally as kala namak. After extraction, the salt is put into a ceramic jar along with charcoal the barks of some trees, and fired for twenty four hours. While the rock was traditionally a rock salt, now even sea salt is used for the process. The distinct taste of the salt was because of the presence of sodium compounds. Now, the salt is also produced by artificially introducing small amounts of various sodium compounds to sea salt, before the firing in the furnace. Black salt is used in chat dishes. Smoked salt is black in colour, and has a strong flavour as well as aroma. It is produced by smoking wood into salt for as many as fourteen days. The woods used include oak and hickory.

A black salt from Hawaii known as pa’akai used to naturally have a black colouring because of it being deposited in ancient lava flows. Most of the salt available now is made by using activated charcoal to provide the black colouration. The extraction process is similar to Fleur de sel in France. Hawaii also produces a sea salt known as Bamboo Jade. Regular sea salt is infused with bamboo leaf extracts, which gives the salt both a green appearance, as well as a distinct flavour. Perhaps the most complex process is the Filipino Asín tibuok. First, coconut husks are soaked in sea water over several months. Then, these husks are burned, and salt water filtered through the ashes. The resulting brine is collected into clay pots, where coconut milk is introduced to the mix. The pot is burned, causing the water and milk to evaporate. During this process, additional coconut milk is constantly introduced to the pots. The process is considered complete when the pots actually crack, revealing a solidified chunk of salt. Considering how labour intensive the preparation process is, the practice is dying out. **1**